

THE DROWNED VALLEY

A Trail Through the History of Dale Hollow Lake

Interpretive Signage Package

Trailhead Introduction · Orientation Map · 24 Interpretive Signs · Closing Sign

Print one sign per page · Portrait · US Letter

Recommended mounting size: 18" × 24" or larger

SIGN 0

Welcome to the Trail

A Walk Through Twelve Thousand Years

Two miles west of here lies Dale Hollow Lake -- 27,700 acres of clear, cold water filling a valley that people have lived in, hunted across, farmed, fought over, and finally flooded.

This trail tells that valley's story, in order, from the Mississippian sea that laid its bedrock to the world-record bass still swimming in its depths.

Along the way you'll meet long hunters and Cherokee leaders, Civil War guerrillas and frontier settlers, the 74 families of a drowned town called Willow Grove, and the Army Corps engineers who closed the gates in 1943.

The lake is young. The story is not. Take your time.

SIGN 1

A Valley Older Than You Can Imagine

The lake two miles from here began as a shallow tropical sea, 330 million years ago.

That sea laid down the thick limestones now exposed in the gorge walls along the Obey River. About 285 million years ago, the Cumberland Plateau lifted up, and rivers began eating their way back into the highlands.

The Obey cut its gorge over the last two million years, working through rock one grain at a time.

SIGN 2

Why the Water Is So Clear

Dale Hollow is one of the clearest lakes in the eastern United States. Visibility often reaches 20 to 30 feet -- clear enough that scuba divers come from across the country.

Three reasons: the watershed has few cities or heavy industry, the bedrock is limestone rather than clay, and the Army Corps keeps nearly all private docks and homes off the shoreline.

The water is also deep and cold. Near the dam it exceeds 120 feet, cold enough to support a lake trout population rarely found this far south.

SIGN 3

The First People

Humans have hunted this country for at least 12,000 years -- since the last Ice Age.

At Rock Creek Mortar Shelter in nearby Pickett State Forest, archaeologists have documented continuous occupation from the end of the Pleistocene through the Mississippian era. Stone blades buried two meters deep suggest not just hunting parties but families, with older knappers teaching apprentices.

The Upper Cumberland, long dismissed as "marginal" land, is now understood as one of the most continuously-used upland landscapes in the Southeast.

SIGN 4

Contested Hunting Ground

By the time Europeans arrived, no single tribe held permanent villages in this region. It was hunting ground and war trail -- shared and disputed by Cherokee, Shawnee, Yuchi, and Chickasaw.

Cherokee leader Nettle Carrier, son of Chief Obed, was the regionally prominent figure. Overton County tradition remembers his people as trading partners with the first settlers at Alpine and Monroe.

Some families in the Willow Grove area traced their land back to a purchase made directly from Nettle Carrier before 1785.

SIGN 5

The Long Hunters, 1769

In the summer of 1769, about twenty men crossed the Cumberland Gap on a long hunt for deer hides. Among them was a man named Obediah Terrill.

They spent their season on a river Terrill's companions called "Obed's River." Over time, Obed's became Obeds, then Obey. The river -- and eventually the lake -- took its name from him.

The Cherokee name for this river was Oocooahustehee -- "good hunting."

SIGN 6

William Dale's Hollow

In 1808, a War of 1812 veteran and government surveyor named William Dale bought 449 acres of Obey River bottomland a few miles northeast of here.

He married Rachael Irons of Willow Grove, and the Dale family farmed that hollow continuously for 134 years -- until 1942, when the federal government arrived with plans for a dam.

When the Corps of Engineers needed a name for the project, local usage had already attached "Dale Hollow" to the farm and the draw above it. The lake took its name from the farm. The farm lies beneath the water today.

SIGN 7

Monroe, Tennessee: Frontier Settlement

In 1799, Colonel Stephen Copland and his son "Big Jo" founded a settlement near Monroe, negotiating a hospitable arrangement with Chief Nettle Carrier.

Monroe became the first seat of Overton County when the county was formed in 1806. Andrew Jackson and John Sevier both acquired land here. Cordell Hull's father made his logging fortune in this country.

Monroe still sits just a few miles from where you're standing.

SIGN 8

Guerrilla War in the Hills

The Civil War in these hills was not an army war. It was a neighbor war.

Clinton County, Kentucky leaned Union. Fentress and Overton counties leaned Confederate. Pickett was bitterly divided. The mountains were too rugged for regular armies to hold, so local men fought a personal war -- cabin against cabin, family against family.

The ferocity of it would be hard to overstate. Feuds that began in the 1860s were sometimes still alive when the dam surveyors arrived eighty years later.

SIGN 9

Champ Ferguson

Samuel "Champ" Ferguson was born in Albany, Kentucky, in 1821. When the war came, he organized a Confederate partisan band and operated across these same hills.

His own brother joined the Union cavalry. Champ swore to kill him on sight -- and others kept count of the men he killed, which by his own admission exceeded a hundred.

He was hanged in Nashville on October 20, 1865 -- one of only three Confederates executed for war crimes after the war. His body was carried home to "pure Rebel soil" near Sparta.

SIGN 10

Tinker Dave Beaty

Champ Ferguson's opposite number was David "Tinker Dave" Beaty of Fentress County, a Unionist guerrilla who led the Independent Scouts.

In the winter of 1862, partisans from both sides met at Monroe -- just a few miles from this trail -- and tried to negotiate a regional peace. They agreed to lay down arms and go home.

Ferguson broke the agreement almost immediately. The killings resumed. Four years later, Tinker Dave would be the most damning witness at Champ's trial.

SIGN 11

Willow Grove

Eastern Clay County, thirteen miles east of Celina. In its final years, Willow Grove was home to 74 families and was the second-largest town in the county.

It had a post office (1884), general stores, a gristmill, the Church of Christ, Willow Grove Academy, and a brick high school built in 1936 with a gymnasium.

Two sons of the community went on to national prominence: Cordell Hull, Secretary of State under FDR and 1945 Nobel Peace laureate, and Arthur Hollis Edens, the fourth president of Duke University.

SIGN 12

The Boy in the Schoolhouse Steps

Eighteen-year-old Eddie Irons was killed in a horse-racing accident in the 1800s and buried on a knoll at Willow Grove.

His grave was unearthed accidentally several times over the decades -- the last time in 1936, when workers built the new brick high school on that hill. Rather than move him again, they encased his walnut casket inside the concrete front steps of the schoolhouse.

When the Corps prepared to flood the valley seven years later, they dynamited the steps to recover him.

SIGN 13

Other Lost Communities

Willow Grove was the largest, but it was not alone.

Lillydale in Pickett County. Cedar Hill, Oak Grove, Maple Grove, Fox Springs, Neely Cross Roads, Free Hill, Tinsley Bottom, Weaver Bottom, Butlers Landing, Pea Ridge, Cave Springs, Bennett Ferry.

Pickett County lost about a quarter of its population and most of its best farmland. Some communities survive only as place names on modern campgrounds and coves.

SIGN 14

The Flood Control Act

The dam was authorized by the Flood Control Act of 1938. The reasoning was simple: spring floods from the Upper Cumberland were devastating downstream towns as far as Nashville.

A dam on the Obey, in a narrow gorge near the river's mouth, could catch a huge watershed and release it slowly. Hydropower was a welcome byproduct.

Unlike most famous Upper Cumberland lakes, Dale Hollow is not a TVA project. It was built by the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers, Nashville District.

SIGN 15

Building the Dam, 1941-1943

The construction contract went to Morrison-Knudsen of Boise -- the same firm that had built Hoover Dam -- three weeks after Pearl Harbor.

Groundbreaking was March 2, 1942. The first concrete was poured June 2, 1942. Over sixteen months, more than 1,000 workers placed 573,760 cubic yards of concrete.

The dam is 200 feet tall and 1,717 feet long. Flood-control operations began October 20, 1943 -- and the lake filled to normal pool on May 7, 1944.

SIGN 16

A Wartime Project

World War II shaped Dale Hollow in two ways.

It sped up the flood-control portion -- the Corps prioritized Dale Hollow as a backup power source in case Axis bombing disabled TVA dams, or for wartime munitions production.

It slowed down the powerhouse -- steel shortages delayed the generators until 1948. When they came online, Dale Hollow became the first completed hydroelectric plant in the entire Cumberland River Basin.

SIGN 17

2,200 Graves

Before the water rose, more than 2,200 graves had to be moved.

Work crews carefully disinterred and relocated burials to eight reception cemeteries in the surrounding counties -- Donaldson, St. John's, Fellowship, Harrison, Webb. Where the bones had dissolved, they reburied "bits of dirt."

Some workers told eerie stories for years afterward. A few descendants still maintain that their families were never paid fair value for the land.

SIGN 18

The Last Picnic

Willow Grove's last full gathering was on July 18, 1942 -- a community picnic on the school grounds. Dr. Clark delivered the farewell speech.

Over the following year the town was demolished. Houses, barns, even school desks were left where they stood and allowed to flood.

Families relocated to higher ground, or scattered across the Upper Cumberland. Within months, many of their sons were off to World War II.

SIGN 19

Ghosts in Clear Water

Every fall, when the Corps lowers the lake for winter pool, the outline of the Willow Grove schoolhouse foundation becomes visible again.

Three rock buoys near the Willow Grove Campground beach mark its location. Divers have reported intact school desks still inside the ruins, and the massive concrete piers of the old Lillydale Bridge still stand underwater.

Descendants of the vanished town still gather -- usually on Labor Day weekend -- for a homecoming that has been documented in local papers since at least 1968.

SIGN 20

A World Record

On July 9, 1955, David Lee Hayes of Leitchfield, Kentucky was trolling a pearl Bomber plug near Trooper Island when he thought he was snagged.

It was a smallmouth bass. 27 inches long. 21-inch girth. 11 pounds, 15 ounces. One ounce shy of twelve.

It was certified as the world record. And it still is, seventy years later -- the longest-standing world record in all of freshwater bass fishing.

SIGN 21

Smallmouth Capital of the World

Dale Hollow doesn't just hold the world-record smallmouth. It holds the top three smallmouth bass positions in world history, and at least seven more in the top twenty-five.

Celina native Billy Westmorland (1937-2002) pioneered finesse fishing for smallmouth here on four- and six-pound line. He wrote *Them Ol' Brown Fish*, hosted a TV fishing show, and was inducted into the Bass Fishing Hall of Fame.

The highway between Celina and Horse Creek Resort is named in his honor.

SIGN 22

The Fish Hatchery

Below the dam, cold water releases created a world-class trout fishery where none existed before.

The Dale Hollow National Fish Hatchery, opened in 1965, is the largest federal trout hatchery east of the Mississippi -- producing about 1.5 million trout and 300,000 pounds of fish each year.

Its stock supplies waters in Tennessee, Georgia, and Alabama. The seven-mile tailwater below the dam has produced historic state records for both rainbow and brown trout.

SIGN 23

Houseboat Capital

Dale Hollow has been rated the top houseboating destination in North America.

The Corps's strict lakeshore policy keeps private docks and homes off nearly all of the 620 miles of shoreline -- which means houseboats can beach almost anywhere along the lake.

In 2025, the Cooper family of Livingston launched the Knot 2 Scrappy here: 122 feet long, 2,700 square feet, five bedrooms. A crowd of more than 20 million people watched the launch on Facebook.

SIGN 24

The Valley Two Miles West

Two miles from this trail, the lake holds a valley with twelve thousand years of human history at its bottom.

A Mississippian sea laid the limestones. The Obey cut the gorge. People sheltered at Rock Creek. Obediah Terrill named the river in 1769. William Dale settled his hollow in 1808. Cordell Hull went to school at Willow Grove. The Corps closed the gates in 1943. David Hayes caught his fish in 1955. Eighty-three years of water over twelve thousand years of story. When you reach the shoreline, you'll be looking at all of it at once.

BEFORE YOU GO

Please Stay on the Trail

This Land Has Stories Still to Tell

The landscape you're walking through is living history. Rock shelters, artifact scatters, old home sites, and family cemeteries lie across this country -- many of them unmarked.

Please stay on the marked trail. Do not dig, remove artifacts, disturb rocks or plants, or climb on any structures you find. What looks like an ordinary rock may be someone's grave marker.

Pack out what you pack in. Leave wildflowers for the next visitor. If you find something unusual, take a photo and note the location -- then report it to staff rather than removing it.

Thaffnk you for helping protect this place for the visitors who come after you.